Department of Science and Technology
Ministry of Science and Technology
Government of India

Post-Offer Implementation Guidelines for Fellowship Holders

of

INSPIRE Fellowship Component

Under

Innovation in Science pursuit for Inspired Research (INSPIRE)

This document provides INSPIRE Fellowship implementation guidelines under the INSPIRE Scheme of the Department of Science and Technology (DST).

The Department of Science and Technology (DST) reserves the right to review and modify these guidelines as and when required.

INSPIRE Fellowship Guidelines

(these new guidelines will be applicable w.e.f. April 2026 onwards)

Mode of Application:

Online through INSPIRE web-portal https://www.online-inspire.gov.in

Online Selection Process:

Two-tier selection process, i.e. screening of eligible applications by an Internal Committee, followed by final selection through an Expert Committee. However, the selection process is expected to be completed within 4-6 months from the last date of submission of application/ requisite documents and the result (provisional/final offer/Rejection) of the selection process will be communicated to the individual selected candidate through the online web-portal (www.online-inspire.gov.in) only. The result shall be uploaded on the respective applicant's INSPIRE web-portal account only.

Applicants who have not been admitted into Ph.D. Program in S&T subject areas prior to submission of application and get a recommendation at Level I, shall be awarded a **Provisional Offer** for INSPIRE Fellowship and they will be given two slots of one month each, separated by a gap of approximately 5-6 months for uploading Ph.D. admission documents during 1-year duration.

Applicants whose INSPIRE Fellowship applications are not recommended for the INSPIRE Fellowship will have to apply for Re-submission by filling the consent form on the INSPIRE web-portal within 30 days from the date of non-recommendation letter. Thereafter, Applicants must upload the updated/ modified research proposal against the reverted research proposal in their INSPIRE web-portal account, once during the immediate next application slot. The application portal will remain active for 30 days in the immediate next slot.

Eligibility:

1st Rank Holders in any recognized University and Academic Institutions (Excluding Autonomous Colleges) in India in Post-Graduate (PG) level examination in Basic/Applied Sciences, including Engineering, Pharmacy, Agricultural Sciences, Medicine and

Veterinary Sciences. 1st Rank should be obtained in university in basic/applied science subject course/program having a batch size of minimum 07 students with minimum 70% marks in aggregate or its equivalent grade in a point scale wherever grading system is followed, for the entire course/ program. 1st Rank Holder shall be in complete degree examination (not just in specialization) during the two-year tenure or more.

OR

INSPIRE Scholar having secured a minimum 70% marks in aggregate or its equivalent grade in a point scale wherever grading system is followed at M.Sc. or an Integrated M.S./ M.Sc. course.

OR

1st Rank Holders in any recognized University and Academic Institutions (Excluding Autonomous Colleges) in India in Bachelor's in Medicine/ B.Sc. /B.Sc. (Hons.) /B.E. /B. Tech /B.V. Sc. /B.V. Sc. & A.H., i.e. bachelor's degree in Basic/Applied Sciences including Engineering, Pharmacy, Agricultural Sciences, Medicine and Veterinary Sciences, having a batch size of minimum 07 students with minimum 75 % marks in aggregate or its equivalent grade in a point scale wherever grading system is followed. 1st Rank Holder shall be in complete degree examination (not just in specialization) during the four-year tenure or more for B.Sc. / B.Sc. (Hons.) / B.E. / B. Tech/ B.V. Sc./ B.V. Sc. & A.H.

OR

INSPIRE Scholar having secured a minimum 75% marks in aggregate or its equivalent grade in a point scale wherever grading system is followed at B.Sc. (Hons.) (4 years) or B. Sc. with Research of minimum 4 years/ 8 Semesters.

However, merely fulfilling the eligibility criteria for the INSPIRE Fellowship will not guarantee for the final offer of fellowship. Subject Expert Committee (SEC) will finally recommend the applications for the award of INSPIRE Fellowship considering the academic merit, research proposal, supervisor's research credentials and host institution etc. parameters on a competitive basis.

Terms and Conditions:

1. General

a. This Fellowship shall be available only for pursuing a full-time Ph.D. program in any recognized University/ Institution/ R&D Laboratory in the country.

b. The Junior Research Fellow (JRF) or Senior Research Fellow (SRF) under this scheme shall be termed as 'INSPIRE Fellow'. The Fellowship shall be governed through the Office Memorandum of this Ministry of Number A.20020/11/97-IFD dated 6th August 2007; 31st March 2010; 21st October 2014 [No. SR/S9/Z-09/2012], SR/S9/Z-08/2018 dated 30th January 2019 and DST/PCPM/Z-06/2022 dated 26th June 2023 shall be liable to be revised from time to time as per Government Order. However, HRA to the Fellows shall also be applicable as per GoI norms, depending upon the location of the Host Institution.

c. The Fellowship shall be tenable for a maximum period of five years from the activation date or completion of the Ph.D. viva-voce, whichever is earlier.

2. Issue of Fellowship Offer:

a. Availing multiple (more than one) fellowships concurrently from different sources shall not be allowed.

b. **Applicants enrolled in Ph.D.:** The INSPIRE Fellowship activation date shall be the day immediately following the closing date of the advertisement or a day after relieving from previous fellowship/ services, whichever is later.

c. **Applicants not enrolled in Ph.D.:** The INSPIRE Fellowship activation date shall be the day immediately following the closing date of the documents uploading slot(s) or a day after relieving from previous fellowship/ service, whichever is later.

If the fellow resigns from a previous fellowship with effect from backdate, even then his/her fellowship activation date will be the day immediately following the closing date of the documents uploading slot(s) or a day after relieving from previous fellowship/ service, whichever is later.

Upon Final INSPIRE Fellowship selection, the Fellow or the Host-Institution/ University shall inform DST about the 'date of joining' of the INSPIRE Fellow, by uploading the **Joining- cum-Acceptance Letter (JCA)** (as per the format available on candidate's web-

portal account) within one month from the date of issue of the final offer, failing which, his/her final offer will be liable for cancellation and no further correspondence shall be entertained in this regard.

3. **Change of Host Institute:**

Since the final selection to offer the INSPIRE Fellowship has the weightage on Research Proposal and type of Host Institute, Fellows are advised to firm up carefully both the Research Proposal and Host Institute before uploading such documents to the INSPIRE Web portal. Considering these, once the Final Offer is made by DST-INSPIRE, the INSPIRE Fellow shall not be allowed to transfer the Fellowship to any other University/ Institute / Laboratory in the country or change of Research Proposal during 5 years of Fellowship tenure in any circumstances, except in extraordinary circumstances such as dislocation due to marriage (for a female candidate), demise of present Research Supervisor, proven case of sexual harassment etc. Even in such cases, the new Research Proposal, CV of the new supervisor and the new Host Institute need to be evaluated again for consideration of any change, and the outcome of the evaluation by the Subject Expert Committee shall be communicated to the Fellow. In case the change is acceptable due to any of the reasons mentioned above, the Fellow must seek prior permission from the DST-INSPIRE for such change of Host Institution by submitting the following documents:

- No Objection Certificates (NOCs) from the respective Host Institutes and Research Supervisors (both old and new),
- Detailed Justifications for change/ transfer of Host Institute for implementation of Fellowship,
- Ph.D. Research area with an up-to-date Technical Progress Report,
- CV of the Research Supervisor at new Host Institute,
- Up-to-date Financial Statement of Expenditure from the initial Host Institute (in case the fellowship grant has been released to the initial host Institute of the INSPIRE Fellow).

However, transfer of Host Institute or change of Research Proposal without prior written permission from DST-INSPIRE may be called for the termination of the INSPIRE Fellowship. In case, a fellow does this at his/ her own discretion without prior permission/ approval, DST-INSPIRE shall be liable for discontinuation of his/her INSPIRE

Fellowship. Moreover, such a shift/ change of Host Institute may be allowed only once in 5 years of Fellowship tenure and that too within one year from the "Activation Date" of Fellowship at the respective Host Institute.

4. Short-Term Research Internship:

a. INSPIRE Fellow shall be allowed to avail a Short-Term Research Internship at any national or International Laboratory/ University/ Institute for a maximum duration of 18 months, either in single or multiple slots during the 5-year tenure of the Fellowship. It shall be arranged by the individual Fellow or the Host Institution. Fellow shall obtain prior permission from DST-INSPIRE on the recommendation of Ph.D. Supervisor as well as confirmation from the Research Internship provider. In case the Fellow receives full financial support for the internship from the overseas institution(s), the INSPIRE Fellowship for the period of Overseas stay will not be remitted.

b. After availing the Research Internship, the Fellow must submit his/her Internship Report as well as Joining Report to the Host Institution, with intimation to DST. Positioning under JSPS-HOPE Program shall be dealt in separately.

5. Release of Fellowship:

Fellowship limit for the INSPIRE Fellow(s) shall be assigned to their respective Host institutions, i.e. Working Institution, by the Department of Science & Technology, New Delhi. Payment of the Fellowship along with Contingency Grant, will be as per the Government of India and the Institute/University norms. For assignment of fellowship limit, Host institute(s) need to have a Zero-balance Subsidiary Account [Preferable Name of A/c: *Institution Name*_Vigyan Dhara] to operate as a Sub Agency A/c at an institutional level (i.e. respective institute/organization) in Union Bank of India and get mapped and flagged the ZBSA in PFMS (Public Finance Management System: https://www.pfms.nic.in). Institute will operationalize the new process i.e. TSA Hybrid 1A for the flow of funds through ZBSA at Union Bank of India for utilization of the Fellowship grant.

a. For Fellowship release in the subsequent years, the Host-Institute or the concerned fellow shall submit the financial year-wise Statement of Expenditure & Utilization

Certificate (through online portal: www.online-inspire.gov.in) for each of the INSPIRE Fellow. Each INSPIRE Fellow shall submit Annual Progress Report duly authenticated by their concerned Ph.D. supervisor.

b. Second installment onwards release to an ongoing Fellow will be considered if the unspent limit from the previously assigned Fellowship limit, including HRA shall be less than Rs. 40,000/-.

6. For **JRF to SRF** upgradation Guidelines, please visit the link revised guidelines for upgradation from JRF to SRF on the INSPIRE online portal **www.online inspire.gov.in.**

7. Completion of Fellowship Tenure or Award of Ph.D. degree:

i. To settle the fellowship grant upon completion of the tenure of the fellowship, INSPIRE Fellow shall upload the following documents in his/her INSPIRE web-portal account:
   a. A copy of the Ph.D. degree certificate,
   b. Ph.D. completion/ discontinuation report,
   c. Statement of Expenditure (SE) and Utilization Certificate (UC) of complete fellowship duration,

ii. Soft copy of the Ph.D. thesis, published research papers and patent details if any shall be submitted in USB storage device to the DST-INSPIRE by speed post.

iii. INSPIRE Fellows must settle their claims within one year of leaving the Fellowship. No claim will be admitted by DST after one year of leaving the Fellowship.

8. Termination or Discontinuation of INSPIRE Fellowship shall occur in the following situations:

i. Non-acceptance of Final Offer within **30** days from the date of issue of Final Offer;

ii. Upon successful completion of Ph.D. viva-voce or 5years of INSPIRE Fellowship tenure, whichever is earlier;

iii. Resignation from the Fellowship before awarding Ph.D. degree based on the Research Supervisor's recommendation and upon acceptance of resignation by DST as per the terms and conditions detailed in point 7 above;

iv. Change of host institution without prior approval of DST;

v. In case an INSPIRE Fellow is found ineligible at any stage, including submission of incorrect information/document(s)/application, any unintentional computer error or printer's devil etc.;

vi. In case of termination of fellowship on unethical ground(s) INSPIRE Fellow is liable to refund the complete released INSPIRE Fellowship grant along with interest.

9. Duties of INSPIRE Fellow:

i. Keep DST updated regarding the Research progress made during the fellowship tenure.

ii. INSPIRE Fellow shall not take any paid or unpaid assignment other than related to his/her approved research program. However, if required, the fellow may assist the host institute in its academic activities as per Ph.D. program guidelines governed by the Host Institution, provided such assignments shall not hamper the progress of the research work of the fellow.

iii. Once the INSPIRE Fellow joins the Fellowship, he/she shall complete the research work within the 5-year tenure of the fellowship to achieve the approved objectives of the research problem.

iv. The INSPIRE Fellow must acknowledge the support provided by DST in all publications (s)/patent(s) and Ph.D. Thesis.

v. Soft copy of the Ph.D. thesis, published research papers and patent details if any, shall be submitted in a USB storage device to the DST-INSPIRE by speed post.

vi. DST needs to be informed about any disciplinary action taken by the University against the INSPIRE Fellow.

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